- National Magazine Company is a subsidiary of the vast Hearst Corporation in America. It publishes seventeen high-circulation consumer magazines in the UK, including *Cosmopolitan* and *Esquire*.
- Future is a smaller company based in Bath specialising in film, computing and sports magazines, including fanzines such as *United*.

KEY TERM

Mode of address the way in which a text creates a relationship with its audience

ACTIVITY 3

1 Research the publishers and circulations of the magazines in Activity 2. Follow the link on Heinemann Hotlinks. Display your results in a table.

Magazine	Publisher	Circulation
OK		

2 Look at your tables from this activity and Activity 2. Which types of magazines have the highest and lowest circulations?

Analysing magazine covers



Magazine publishing is a hugely profitable and growing media industry. It is also very competitive. Your research in Activity 1 showed you some techniques used by magazines to address their audiences by capturing their interest on the shelf. Now you are going to look closely at a magazine cover and analyse its features. This is an excellent way to find out what messages a magazine is conveying to its audience.

To be successful a magazine must establish a close, personal and almost friendly relationship with its readers. Magazines are all about **mode of address**. This is often through the person featured in the text. On the cover in **2** the person is looking straight out at the reader; this is known as a *direct mode of address*. When the person is looking away, and therefore inviting the reader to look on, but to be less involved, the text is using an *indirect mode of address*. This gives clues about the type of magazine it is and the relationship it wants to have with its audience.

Now look at the annotations on **2**. You already know what *mode of address* means. Try to make sure that you understand the other terms in **bold** that are used in the annotations. It is important to use the correct terms when you analyse any media text. Other key terms that you might use when you analyse a magazine cover are:

- **seasonal theme**: when the colours and contents of a magazine relate to the time of year, e.g. red hearts and features on romance for St Valentine's Day
- **mise-en-scene**: the way in which every element of the text is arranged to create a meaning
- **anchorage text**: writing that fixes the meaning of an image, e.g. a caption
- **blurb**: factual information, often in small print.

TIP

Using the correct terms and language when you analyse a text is a really good way to get more marks.

The **price** is placed in an eye-catching 'star' to attract the eye and act as a persuasive technique.

The **slogan** tries to convince the reader that this magazine is better than its rivals.

The **central image** of Kym Marshall relies on the audience knowing that she was in the band Hearsay and married Jack Ryder from *EastEnders*. Kym is represented in a fashionable dress that shows off her figure – the **anchorage text** suggests that she has lost weight – and she uses **direct mode of address**, smiling into the eyes of the reader to share her happiness with them.

The **title** of the magazine connotes an up-to-the-minute feel, suggesting that readers will be reading the most recent events in the lives of the celebrities featured.

The word 'exclusive' is a **buzz word** suggesting that this magazine is the only one to cover this story.



© NOW/IPC Syndication

The arrow is a **graphic feature** to add interest to the question being posed.

Puffs at the bottom of the page suggest that the magazine will give fashion and beauty tips – assuming that the reader is concerned with their appearance.

The three **images** are linked by theme – they all feature stars and their babies – and by the story title which acts as **anchorage text**. The story relies on the audience knowing who the stars are and that they are now parents. It also assumes that readers want to know about the private lives of stars.

1 Analysing a magazine cover

ACTIVITY 4

Now have a go at analysing the magazine front cover in **3** yourself. *Hotdog* is a specialist film magazine aimed at 15–35-year-old males with an interest in film. Try to identify how the cover has been made to appeal to its audience.

- Remember to use the correct terms whenever you can.
- Look back at how the cover in **2** was analysed if you need help.



Hotdog's readers are mainly male filmgoers aged 15 to 35 years

Who reads magazines?

Considering the ways in which audiences read or watch different media texts is a very important part of media studies. The best way to start is with YOU, since so many texts are aimed at people like you. You are part of the powerful 14–18-year-old audience, and media producers are very interested to know what you like and what you want.

Can you think why your age group is so powerful? The main reason is that, even though you don't usually earn large sums of money, what you do earn is virtually all **disposable income** – there is only you to spend it on. After all, most young people do not have to pay for food or housing, so media producers want you to spend your money on their products. Producers also want readers with spending power to attract advertisers who subsidise the cost of production. The money advertisers pay for space in print-based texts is used to reduce the selling price. Without **subsidisation**, print-based media texts would cost over twice as much.

KEY TERMS

Disposable income the money someone has left to spend after they have paid for essentials such as housing and food

Subsidisation reducing the cover price of a media text such as a magazine or newspaper by selling advertising space

When and how do people consume media texts?

Audiences consume, that is, watch, read or listen to, media products in a whole range of situations and places, sometimes while doing other things, sometimes with focused attention. This is sometimes known as *pattern of consumption*. How is the girl in **4** consuming the text?.

reinforcing female **stereotypes** – for example, girls and women can make themselves ill trying to look like the models in the pictures. What do you think?

Age

Try to avoid making sweeping statements about the age of a target audience, such as: 'This text is aimed at teenagers'. You might find the following breakdown helpful:

Under 5 6–8 9–12 13–15 16–18 19–25 26–40 41–60 Over 60

ACTIVITY 8

Imagine you are a media producer considering at which audience to aim your latest product. What do you know about people of different ages?

List and discuss the probable lifestyle, likes and dislikes of people in these age groups: 6–8; 16–18; 25–40; over 60.

Ask yourself about their hobbies, their favourite night out, the TV programmes they watch, etc. How might a media producer use this information?

People over 60 are likely to: have low disposable income; have similar, non-active lifestyles; not enjoy violence; enjoy films and programmes from the past.

When target audiences are described in this way, the various categories are being stereotyped. The description of people over 60 in Activity 8 may be true for many people, but it is important to remember that some over-60s still earn high salaries, run marathons, enjoy thrillers and go to pop concerts!

Ethnicity

Although ethnicity is not always relevant, the racial or religious background of an audience may be a factor affecting what a text contains. For example, *Asiana Wedding* is a magazine that targets Asian women.



5 Ethnicity is a major factor in the audience targeting of *Asiana Wedding*

KEY TERMS

Stereotype how a certain group of people is represented

Values and aspirations the ideas and aims that are important to people and that they aim at or wish for

ACTIVITY 9

Find out what magazines are most popular with people in your school. Try to ask students who represent a mix of ages, genders and ethnic backgrounds. What links can you see between these factors and the magazines people enjoy? Present your findings in the form of a chart, graph or table and discuss in class.

Lifestyle

Being able to discuss the possible lifestyle and habits of an audience is important. Try to consider the **values and aspirations** (ideology) of the audience of a text you are analysing. Media producers research their audiences well, to find out what kinds of things are important to them, so that the messages in their texts will appeal to them and make them respond positively to them. Ask yourself how the text highlights (and perhaps reinforces) those values.

Look again at the front cover of *Now* magazine on page 85.

- It suggests that the audience might be anxious about their appearance – note the '8 pages of holiday fashion' and Kym's 'diet secrets'.
- The audience are obviously very interested in stories about stars and celebrities, and probably use pictures of them to provide role models of beauty, fame and success.
- The magazine assumes that readers will want to know as much about the personal lives of celebrities as possible, in this case featuring stars and their babies.



6 *Mizz* magazine, November 2003

© MIZZ/IPC Syndication

ACTIVITY 10

Look closely at the front cover of *Mizz* in **6**. Write bullet points to suggest:

- the likely audience of the magazine
- the kinds of features that might be appealing to this audience.

- *Presentation:* How much of the publication is given over to photos? Are any drawings used? How many different styles of print are used? Are the colours bright and brash or muted and subtle?
- *Audience:* What kind of reader are the products aimed at? How do you know?
- *Front pages or covers:* These are a crucial part of any publication. They are the way potential readers are 'grabbed' as they look along the racks in newsagents. What does the front cover tell you about the sort of readership being targeted? What idea of the content of the magazine does the cover give? How does the combination of pictures and words encourage people to buy the publication? What kind of lifestyle is being catered for by this magazine?
- *Advertising:* newspapers and magazines need to sell advertising space to help cover the cost of production. What products are being advertised and what does this tell you about the sorts of readers being targeted?

Production

When you have decided on your target audience, draw up your production schedule. This is a list of all the things which need to be done, who will be doing them and the deadlines which need to be met.

Stage 1: Planning the content

Draw up a list of all the articles you wish to include and how many pages you can realistically produce in the time you have been given. It is much better to produce fewer high-quality pages than a lot of articles which are poorly written and badly laid out because you have tried to do too much in too short a space of time.

As a guideline, think in terms of each individual being responsible for two double-page spreads. The person responsible for the cover could count that as the equivalent of a double page. Anyone designing a full-page advertisement could also substitute that for a double-page spread.

Once you have a clear outline of what the finished product will look like, divide up the writing and photography tasks among the members of your group.

Stage 2: Writing the articles

You might be able to write some articles immediately, but others will need to be researched or require an interview to be arranged. You might decide at this stage that one of the group will act as a picture researcher. Their job will be to search the Internet and collect a range of pictures which might be useful for each article so that a wide choice is available at the page design stage.

Ideally you will have two *production meetings* where the whole group come together and review the work.

The first one should be halfway through the writing stage. The main purpose will be to check that everyone is running to time, and if not, take immediate action to make sure any problems are overcome. Are you able to extend your deadlines? If not, are you going to have to drop some articles? Will there be sufficient content left to ensure each group member can show how much they know about producing whatever product you have chosen to make? Are the pictures that have been collected appropriate?

The second production meeting will come at the end of the process of writing. You should all read each other's work in a productive, critical way and suggest any

amendments which might be necessary. At this stage you should make a mock-up of the front page or cover and decide on a title for the paper or magazine. Anyone who has been designing a full-page advert should present their ideas at this meeting. Finally, you need to list any photographs that need to be taken.

Stage 3: Photo shoots

The photograph for the front cover of a magazine should be very carefully planned. Photographs used in advertisements also need to be thought through and a variety of alternatives taken from which the best one can be chosen.

For a professional fashion/advertisement shoot there will be a number of people involved:

- art director (in overall charge of the shoot)
- photographer (takes the photos and makes suggestions to the art director)
- two or three photographer's assistants to carry gear and set up lights
- stylist (to supervise costume and make-up)
- the client or their representative (to check they are happy with what is being photographed)
- the model or models.

You will probably have a much smaller crew, but you should certainly involve more than one person. Above all you need to look at every single detail of the images that you take to make sure that the photograph is conveying exactly the right message to your audience.

When posing any models for each photograph, use the following checklist:

- *Posture:* how will I pose the model? Lazing on a sofa will give a relaxed feel to the image; sitting upright in an office chair will give a more formal feel.
- *Facial expression:* do I want to create a moody look? Or do I want a happy, relaxed feel to the shot?
- *Costume:* what someone wears tells other people a great deal about them. Make sure that each piece of your model's clothing has been selected to get across the chosen image.
- *Setting and props:* think about the message that the setting of your shot will convey, and any props you use. Is the school playing field *really* the best setting for your jeans advert – or have you just gone there because it is easy? Is your teacher's N-reg. Fiesta going to add to the 'cool image' you are trying to create?

Once you have all of the things on that checklist sorted out, your next job is to compose them within the frame of your camera. Although there is no hard-and-fast set of rules about what makes a good photograph, the following composition guidelines might offer you a starting point for making interesting images.

Using thirds

Where will you place significant elements in your picture? Research has shown that viewers look first at the human face – especially the eyes – and any points of high contrast. Photographers often talk about the *principle of thirds*. When looking through the viewfinders of their cameras, they imagine a grid formed by two vertical and two horizontal lines which divide the picture into thirds. They then place key elements of the composition, often using a one-third to two-thirds proportion. Look at photograph **10** and think about the way it has used thirds for its composition.



10 This photo was composed using the principle of thirds

Lines of movement

Photographs are often thought to have a stronger composition if the objects in them are seen as 'moving into' the picture – see **11**.



11 The men are looking into the right of this frame

Diagonals and horizontals

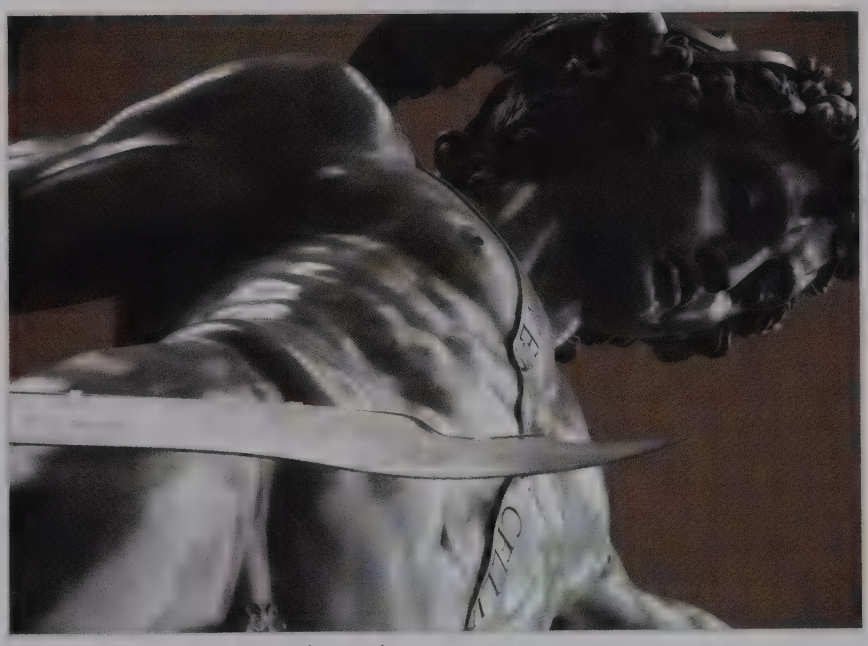
Diagonal lines in compositions are said to be more dynamic than horizontal ones. How have lines been used in the composition in image **12**?



12 St Marks Square, Venice

Angle

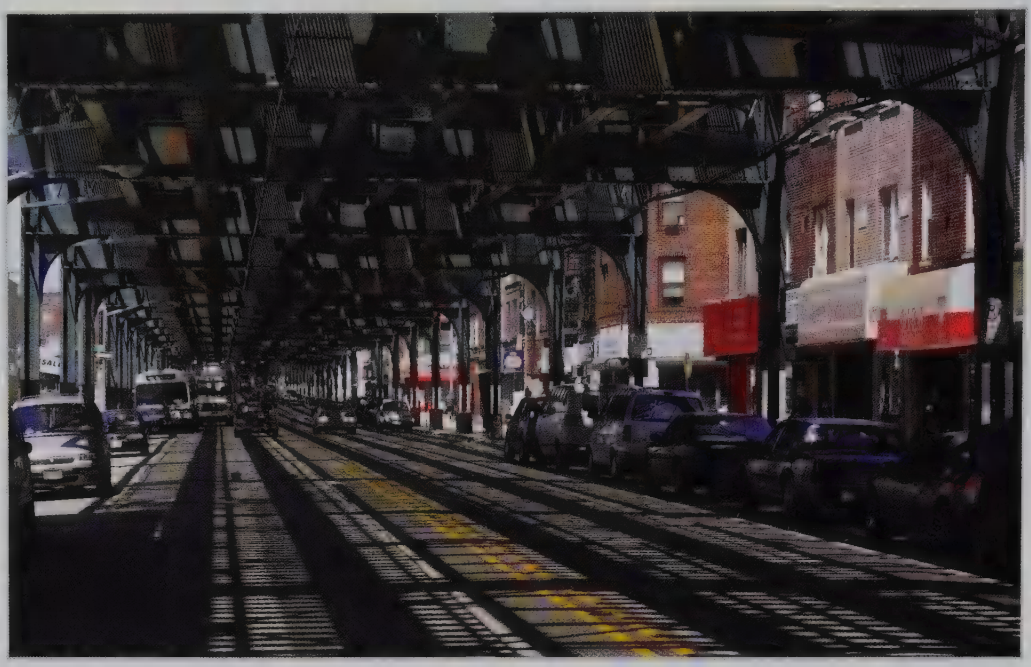
Most photographs are taken at eye level. Taking them from above or below, as in **13**, your subject can be another way of creating visual impact.



13 This photo was taken from a low angle

Light

Getting the lighting right can mean more than just making sure there is enough light. The factors mentioned for video production on page 175 apply equally to lighting for a still photograph. Strong sunlight coming through the overhead railway in Brooklyn adds to the composition of photograph **14**.



14 Lighting is an important feature of this composition

Post-production

With your articles written and imagery produced, you now need to decide the order in which articles will appear and – crucially – how they are to be laid out on the page. It is the presentation of your publication that would sell it in the real world.

Using a computer software package at the page design stage will obviously be a great advantage as you can quickly and easily manipulate both your written work and your images. Being able to see the effect of changes in layout and font makes experimentation easy. However, you can still use older methods of cutting up and pasting your work directly onto paper. Remember: you should be thinking about the *appropriateness* of your design to your intended audience as well as how to grab and keep a reader's attention.

Some hints on layout

- Look at a wide range of different publications and make notes of layout features which you think would be good to incorporate in your production.
- Use a page grid to help you in your page design, even if you decide to break out of it. This is how all page designs in professional publications start out – see the example in **15**.
- The various parts of the design do not have to be straight or orderly. Scattered letters can add to the dynamic look of the page. However, if you use straight lines and columns, make sure they are just that!
- Use blank space. It can provide contrast in your design. If everything is spaced out evenly it can look bland and uninteresting.
- Titles set on a diagonal can add emphasis and look more dynamic.
- If your production is using a double-page spread which is to be folded and stapled, make a small dummy version that includes the same number of pages. Number the pages, then separate them to see which page goes with which on the paste-up. You can see the page combinations for a sixteen-page booklet in image **16**.